The Seahorse Lookalike That Is Not a Seahorse at All

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At first glance, this thumb-sized fish looks like a seahorse. It has a horse-shaped head tilted down, a curled tail, and a pouch for the young in males. But scientists say it is not a seahorse. In a new study in the Journal of Lost Species, they describe **Australyichthys aegis**, from deep reefs off southern Australia. They call it the helmethead sea muppet for its helmet-like **crest**. With the bullneck sea muppet and the paradoxical sea muppet, it forms a new group, Australyichthys. Only seven are known, found over about 65 years along more than 2,500 kilometers of coast. None has been collected in nearly two decades. They live 50 to 125 meters deep and were caught by accident in nets. The A. aegis fish came up in 2006 near the Gambier Islands. Scientists could not **dissect** them, so **micro-CT** scans made 3D models of their skeletons. True seahorses have belly plates and a bony crown called a **coronet**; Australyichthys has neither. DNA from one preserved fish also placed it outside seahorses. Scientists call this look-alike pattern **convergent evolution**.

Word Treasure

Australyichthys aegis -- It is the scientific name given to this new fish.

crest -- It is a raised shape on top of the fish's head, like a helmet.

dissect -- It means to carefully cut something open to look inside it.

coronet -- It is a bony crown on top of a true seahorse's head.

convergent evolution -- It is when different animals end up looking alike even though they are not closely related.

micro-CT -- It is a kind of scan that makes a 3D model of something inside, like a skeleton.

Background you need

A seahorse is a small fish with a horse-shaped head, a curled tail, and a pouch where males carry the young.

The helmethead sea muppet looks like a seahorse, but it has no belly plates and no bony crown, so scientists place it in a new group outside true seahorses.

When unrelated animals grow similar shapes, scientists call that convergent evolution.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists studying a thumb-sized fish called Australyichthys aegis, also called the helmethead sea muppet, along with the bullneck sea muppet and the paradoxical sea muppet

WHAT: Scientists described a new group, Australyichthys, for fish that look like seahorses but lack belly plates and a coronet

WHERE: Deep reefs off southern Australia, including near the Gambier Islands, at 50 to 125 meters deep

WHY: DNA from one preserved fish and skeleton scans placed it outside seahorses, showing a look-alike pattern scientists call convergent evolution

Why it matters

It shows you that two creatures can look almost the same yet still be different, so checking small details matters when you compare things in everyday life.

Test what you remember

1. What is the scientific name given to the helmethead sea muppet?

- (A) The bullneck sea muppet
- (B) The paradoxical sea muppet
- (C) A true seahorse
- (D) Australyichthys aegis

2. Why do scientists say Australyichthys is not a seahorse?

- (A) It has a curled tail
- (B) It lives on deep reefs
- (C) It has neither belly plates nor a bony crown called a coronet
- (D) It was caught by accident in nets

3. Where did the A. aegis fish come up in 2006?

- (A) In a laboratory tank
- (B) Near the Gambier Islands
- (C) In a shallow rock pool
- (D) Along a short stretch of beach

4. How deep do these fish live?

- (A) 500 to 600 meters deep
- (B) 50 to 125 meters deep
- (C) 5 to 10 meters deep
- (D) Just below the surface

5. How did scientists make 3D models of the skeletons when they could not dissect the fish?

- (A) By guessing from photographs
- (B) By taking the fish apart anyway
- (C) By drawing them from memory
- (D) With micro-CT scans

6. How many of these fish are known?

- (A) Exactly two
- (B) Only seven
- (C) About sixty-five
- (D) More than one hundred

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Scientists: Australyichthys aegis is not a seahorse because it lacks belly plates and a coronet and its DNA places it outside seahorses, a look-alike pattern they call convergent evolution.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):